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STUDY NOTES

NDMA, SDMA & DDMA: India's Disaster Management Framework

DISASTER MANAGEMENT

GENERAL STUDIES

Complete breakdown of India's three-tier disaster management structure under the DM Act 2005 — NDMA, SDMA, DDMA, NDRF, and NIDM with comparison tables for UPSC.



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ENVIRONMENT

NDMA, SDMA & DDMA

- Why the DM Act 2005 Was Enacted
- NDMA: National Disaster Management Authority
- The Executive Committee — The Real Operationa...

SDMA stands for the State Disaster Management Authority and DDMA for the District Disaster Management Authority — the state- and district-level tiers of India's disaster-management system created by the Disaster Management Act, 2005, alongside the NDMA (National Disaster Management Authority) at the Centre. The NDMA is chaired by the Prime Minister, the SDMA by the Chief Minister, and the DDMA by the District Collector/Magistrate.

India's disaster management architecture is a **three-tier system** created by the [Disaster Management Act 2005](#). The structure is straightforward: **NDMA** at the centre, **SDMA** at the state level, and **DDMA** at the district level. The district collector is the actual first responder. Everything else is coordination and guidelines.

This is one of the most frequently tested topics in GS Paper III. UPSC has asked about it in Prelims 2009, 2013, 2015 (NDRF specifically), and Mains 2013, 2017, and 2022. If you do not know the [DM Act 2005](#) structure cold, you are leaving marks on the table.

Why the DM Act 2005 Was Enacted

The 2004 [Indian Ocean Tsunami](#) killed over 10,000 people in India and exposed a



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hoc, coordination between centre and states was chaotic and there was no permanent force trained



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Before 2005, for droughts and famines — a colonial hangover). The Orissa Super Cyclone of 1999 and the Gujarat Earthquake of 2001 had already demonstrated the need for a dedicated framework, but it took the tsunami to force legislative action.

The **Disaster Management Act 2005** created a complete institutional framework from the national to the district level. It also established dedicated response forces and training institutions. The Act defines "disaster" broadly — covering natural, man-made, and technological hazards.

NDMA: National Disaster Management Authority

The **NDMA** is the apex body for [disaster management in India](#). Here are the facts you need:

- **Chairperson:** Prime Minister (ex-officio)
- **Members:** Maximum 9, nominated by the PM. One member designated as Vice-Chairperson
- **Established:** 2005 under the DM Act
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi

Functions:

- Lay down policies and plans for disaster management
- Approve the **National Disaster Management Plan**
- Issue guidelines for different types of disasters
- Coordinate enforcement and implementation
- Recommend provision of funds for mitigation
- Provide support to other countries affected by major disasters (if requested by the central government)



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The Executive Committee – The Real Operational Body

This is what r
the **Home Se**



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chaired by

implementation. The NEC includes secretaries from key ministries — Agriculture, Atomic Energy, Defence, Environment, Health, and others.

The NEC prepares the National Plan, coordinates response during disasters, and monitors preparedness. For Mains answers, always mention the NEC when discussing NDMA's operational mechanisms. UPSC expects you to know that the PM does not operationally manage disasters — the NEC and the Home Secretary do.

Common student mistake: Writing that the PM "manages" disasters through NDMA. The PM chairs NDMA for policy and guidelines. Day-to-day operations run through the NEC chaired by the Home Secretary, and actual on-ground response happens through DDMA and NDRF.

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SDMA: State Disaster Management Authority

Every state has its own SDMA, mirroring the national structure:

- **Chairperson:** Chief Minister (ex-officio)
- **Members:** Maximum 9, nominated by the CM
- **Function:** Lay down state policies and plans, coordinate with NDMA, approve state disaster management plan

The SDMA is supposed to be the **state-level equivalent of NDMA** — setting state-specific guidelines, approving the State Disaster Management Plan, and coordinating state-level response.

The reality is mixed. Some states like Gujarat, Odisha, and Kerala have strong SDMAs with dedicated staff and budgets. These three states learned from catastrophic disasters (Gujarat 2001 earthquake, Orissa 1999 cyclone, Kerala 2018 floods) and built capacity. Other states treat SDMA as a formality. Many SDMAs have not updated their state disaster management plans in years.

[State Executive Committee \(SEC\)](#)



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Like the NEC at the centre, each state has a **State Executive Committee** chaired by the **Chief Secretary**. The committee prepares the state plan, and



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State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF)

Each state maintains an SDRF for immediate disaster response. The centre contributes **75%** of the SDRF corpus for general category states and **90%** for special category states and UTs. This is a frequently tested Prelims fact.

DDMA: District Disaster Management Authority

The DDMA is where disaster management actually happens. India's districts are the **operational units** for disaster response.

- **Chairperson:** District Collector / District Magistrate
- **Co-Chairperson:** Elected representative (Chairperson of Zila Parishad in rural areas, Municipal head in urban areas)
- **Function:** Prepare and implement the District Disaster Management Plan, coordinate response, conduct mock drills, ensure early warning dissemination

The District Collector has **enormous power** during disasters — they can requisition resources, direct evacuations, and coordinate all agencies within the district. This is the person who actually manages the crisis on the ground.

District Disaster Management Plans should be context-specific documents covering hazard mapping, vulnerability assessment, resource inventory, standard operating procedures, and communication protocols. In practice, many district plans are generic templates that have not been updated to reflect local realities.

Common student mistake: Ignoring the DDMA in answers and focusing only on NDMA and NDRF. UPSC specifically values the district-level perspective. The 2017 Mains question on disaster management expected discussion of local-level institutional capacity.



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NDRF: National Disaster Response Force



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The **NDRF** is
2005.

the DM Act

- **Current strength:** 16 battalions (12 operational + 4 being raised)
- **Personnel per battalion:** Approximately 1,149
- **Parent forces:** Battalions drawn from BSF, CRPF, CISF, ITBP, and SSB
- **Headquarters:** New Delhi
- **Training:** Specialized in 12 types of disasters including floods, earthquakes, CBRN (chemical, biological, radiological, nuclear), and building collapse

The NDRF has been deployed for every major disaster since its creation — Uttarakhand floods (2013), Chennai floods (2015), Kerala floods (2018, 2019), Cyclone Amphan (2020), Cyclone Biparjoy (2023), and numerous landslide and flood operations.

NDRF battalions are pre-positioned during disaster seasons. Before cyclone season, battalions move to vulnerable coastal areas. Before monsoon, they deploy to flood-prone districts. This proactive positioning has significantly reduced response times.

Each battalion is trained and equipped for specific disaster types. Some battalions specialize in **CBRN response** (chemical, biological, radiological, nuclear), which is increasingly important given industrial hazards and the threat of technological disasters.

NIDM: National Institute of Disaster Management

The **National Institute of Disaster Management** is the training and capacity-building arm of India's DM framework.

- **Location:** New Delhi
- **Function:** Training, research, documentation, and policy advisory
- **Mandate:** Develop training modules, conduct programmes for DM officials at all levels, undertake research on disaster risk reduction

NIDM runs training programmes for NDMA, SDMA, and DDMA officials. It also works



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NDMA vs

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PARAMETER	NDMA	SDMA	DDMA
Level	National	State	District
Chairperson	Prime Minister	Chief Minister	District Collector/Magistrate
Max Members	9 (nominated by PM)	9 (nominated by CM)	7
Executive Body	NEC (Home Secretary)	SEC (Chief Secretary)	District-level officers
Primary Role	Policy, guidelines, national coordination	State plans, state coordination	Operational response, local implementation
Plan Approved	National DM Plan	State DM Plan	District DM Plan
Funding	NDRF, PM's National Relief Fund	SDRF (75% centre, 25% state)	Through SDRF allocation + local resources
Operational Strength	Advisory — does not deploy directly	Coordination — activates state forces	Direct operations — the first responder

Key Issues and Challenges

Overlapping jurisdictions. During major disasters, coordination between NDMA, SDMA, DDMA, NDRF, armed forces, and state police creates confusion. The Kerala floods (2018) saw initial coordination failures between state agencies and central forces



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Poor state-level capacity. Most SDMAs are understaffed and underfunded. Bihar, Assam, and U  Get the latest UPSC notes and current affairs delivered to you. structure remains inad

Fund utilization gaps. States often fail to utilize SDRF allocations fully. The 15th Finance Commission noted that several states had significant unspent SDRF balances even as disaster-affected populations waited for relief.

Missing local planning. District Disaster Management Plans are supposed to be living documents, updated annually. In practice, many districts have not updated their plans since they were first drafted. Integration with [environmental impact assessments](#) and [climate risk data](#) is virtually absent.

Urban disaster management gap. The DM Act's framework was designed for a rural-administrative paradigm. Cities like Mumbai, Chennai, and Bengaluru face unique disaster risks — urban flooding, [heat waves](#), [air pollution emergencies](#) — that the existing framework handles poorly. Municipal corporations are not adequately integrated into the DDMA structure.

NDRF limitations. 16 battalions for a country of 1.4 billion people across diverse hazard zones is insufficient. Pre-positioning helps, but simultaneous disasters in multiple regions stretch capacity thin.

UPSC Relevance

Prelims: NDMA chairperson (PM), NDRF battalion count (16), SDRF funding ratio (75:25/90:10), DM Act year (2005), DDMA chair (District Collector). These are frequently asked factual questions.

Mains GS3: Questions on institutional effectiveness, centre-state coordination during disasters, and reforms needed in DM architecture. Always include the district level in your answers — that is where UPSC sees depth.

Mains GS2: The DM Act intersects with federalism (centre-state relations during disasters), local governance (role of Zila Parishad in DDMA), and governance reform topics.



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